Defining Your Worth – A Collection

By Savannah Brown, Dustin Lang and Shasparay Lighteard

What Guys Look for in Girls by Savannah Brown

When I first learned that no one could ever love me more
than me
a world of happiness previously unseen was discovered
because somewhere along the line of aging and scrutiny
and time
I was taught to despise myself
but i made sure I kept myself beautiful so someone would
love me someday
so i could belong to someone someday
because that's the most important thing a little girl could
ever want . . . right?

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INTRODUCTION

Author Stephen Chbosky, in his novel The Perks of Being a Wallflower, wrote: "We accept the love we think we deserve."

But let's face it: Cynicism and pessimism are becoming a staple of our society. Blame social media, blame politics, blame the pandemic. The fact is, it has become harder and harder to believe that we are worthy, that we deserve love and we are not, should not and cannot be defined by the world around us.

Defining Your Worth – A Collection including What Guys Look for in Girls by Savannah Broan, I Have Worth by Dustin Lang and Love Yourself by Shasparay Lighteard.

What Guys Look for in Girls by Savannah Brown (Cont'd)

I was 13 the first time i was embarrassed about my body
of course it would not be the last
I remember stuffing my bra in the morning
tears stinging my eyes
hoping, praying to something that I could look beautiful
enough today braces and all
for the ruthless boys who mercilessly told me I was
worthless because my boobs weren't big enough
and i would go home and put on a sweatshirt with my eyes

closed
denying myself the right to be shown myself
because I didn't dare want to insinuate beauty in regards to
something so insulting as my body.

But, I mean, we all end up with our heads between our
knees
because the only place we'll ever really feel safe is inside
skin we've been taught to hate
by a society that shuns our awful confidence and feeds us
our own flaws
and sometimes when i need to meet the me that loves me.
I can't find her
a reminder that the mirror is meant to be a curse
so I confine her in my mind
but when he or she shouts, "Let me out!"
we are allowed to listen.

But it's met by a chorus of conceited, egotistical narcissists
But since when was self-solicitude a sin?
Since when was loving who we are made an offense by
morons who do not matter?

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change this physicality and that one
don't you dare shatter the notion that you could ever be
anything beyond paper fine flesh and flashy teeth and
fingernails
echoic accusations of Not good enough
Never good enough
Have you ever felt so numb that it hurts?
Entertain me . . . or . . .

You can't surrender to them
you gotta remember you're the only thing you'll ever truly
have
and no i don't mean your body
because someday that will go bad no matter what you do
I mean you.

I mean the way your bright eyes go wild when you smile
and your laughter's so melodic it's a song
I mean the way your creativity's compass that leads you to
what you love
and you don't need any miracle cream to keep your
passions smooth hair free

and you don't need any diet pills to slim down your
kindness
and when you start to drown in these petty expectations
you better reexamine the miracle of your existence;
because you are worth so much more than your waistline.
You're worth the beautiful thoughts you think
and the daring dreams you dream,
but sometimes we forget that

because we live in a world where the media
pulls us from the womb, nurses us and
teaches us our first words
Girls: soft, quiet. pretty
Boys: manly, muscles, pretty
But i don't care whether it's your gender, your looks, your
weight, your skin or where your love lies
none of that matters
because standards don't define you.

You don't live to meet the credentials established by a
madman.

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You're a treasure whether you want to believe it or no.t
And maybe that's what everyone should start looking for

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Savannah Brown
ISBN: On-Line Transcript
Publisher: NSDA 2014 Light the Stage Spoken-Word Poetry Showcase (2014 NSDA Tournament)
Date (Month/Year): Jan 27, 2015
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=N-ezbk0AOCI

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I Have Worth by Dustin Lang (Excerpts)

From the day I was born I had one question that plagued
my mind
And it wouldn't leave me so in my late night hours
I would try to find a kind of answer that would satisfy this
uncertainty of mine
Do I have worth?

So I did all I could to prove that I did
I practiced, I prepared, and I performed
Sometimes I performed well and my worth appreciated
And I knew it because others would tell me
They told me that I mattered

They told me that I was valued

They told me that I was seen

But there was a dark side to these reactions . . .

Sometimes I failed

Sometimes I performed poorly and my worth depreciated

And I knew it because others would tell me

They told me that I messed up

They told me that I had no value

They told me that I was clearly seen or rather that my mistakes were

So the thought that plagued my mind

It never declined it only increased like a plus sign

Do I have worth?

I may fail 100 times, I may fail 1000 times, I may fail 10,000 times

But nothing will change the truth that has liberated this heart of mine

I have worth

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And today I boldly proclaim the conclusion to the question that crushed me like cancer

Then freed me when I found the answer

That I have worth

And so do you

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dustin Lang
ISBN: On Line Transcript
Publisher: You Tube.com
Date (Month/Year): Feb 16, 2014
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NNf9RS0UJxc

Love Yourself by Shasparay Lighteard
(Excerpts from her TedxTalk)

I'm the girl they told to be a little quieter in the choir

I'm the girl that never quite learned how to whisper

I'm the girl that usually takes a step back from the mic

You wouldn't believe it,

but when I was younger I was a quiet thing

I knew how to make a meal out of silence

but I've grown to refuse to swallow

Now I have dangerous lips and a pretty smile

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that conceals my sharp tongue
I'm often told I have a big mouth
I talk too much
I'm loquacious
Don't know how to shut my trap
I'm too loud . . . Too much

They say, "Girl, you got too much bark.
We put dogs to sleep for not knowing how to hush.
We make examples of those who refused
to be broken."

We learn early that being loud is a bad thing
We used our whisper voices and played the silent game
'Cause Chatty Cathy is never welcome at the table
Women learn how to be digestible
How to sit . . . smile . . . be taken and be grateful

Silence can be painful
I've refused to quell myself for anyone else
Someone once told me I would never be married
if I did not learn my place
To her I say: My megaphone

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of a throat has too much girth for a leash
Do not expect soft when there is only growl and grit
Ain't no lullabies left in my throat.
When I sing, best believe it is my soul crawling from the light

(Singing) Do you know why the caged bird sings?
Do you know why the caged bird sings?

I speak because I have to
I speak for the many who don't
who continue to be silenced
who are constantly shushed
I speak for them because I know how it feels

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Shasparay Lighteard
ISBN: On Line Transcript
Publisher: TedxYouth@Austin
Date (Month/Year): May 13, 2016
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q9VxIaF0TUM

AWARD HISTORY

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